

Q SHOULD I BE CALM AND UNDER THE SOCIAL VAGUS OR SATTVIC STATE ALL THE TIME?

No. Yoga does teach our bodies to go into the sattvic state more often and more efficiently. This helps us to find balance in a world dominated by extremes of rajas and tamas. However, there is a misconception that yoga should make you perfectly calm all the time and that if that doesn't happen, you are bad at yoga. Constant calm is not the goal.

Your nervous system dynamically fluctuates, as do the gunas, throughout the day and over the

course of your life to help you rise to the challenges your environment presents. Through yoga, you cultivate the capacity to be a non-judgmental observer of the constant changes so they don't control you. The ultimate ideal of this higher state of pure consciousness (also known as Purusha) is self-realization: finding meaning and connection amid the experience of inevitable stressors. Increased consciousness of any level represents increased resilience.

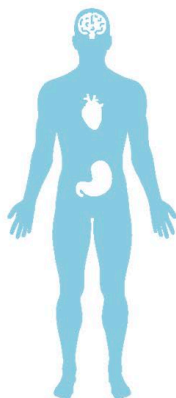
Q HOW CAN I RECOGNIZE AND REBALANCE THE NEGATIVE GUNAS?

The first step is to notice the signals of stress and the negative gunas in your body. These signals are different for everybody. Does your chest tighten or gut churn in an agitated, rajasic state? Do you tend to slouch or disassociate from sensations in a dull, tamasic state? Once you can recognize, identify, and observe your signals effectively,

you can use the tools of yoga—including physical poses, mudras, breathwork, and meditation—to activate the relaxation response. Many yoga practices can be done discreetly throughout the day: no one will know that you are elongating your exhales to calm down, adjusting your posture, or taking fuller breaths for more energy.

Did you know?

80 PERCENT OF THE VAGUS NERVE'S FIBERS SEND **INFORMATION** FROM THE BODY TO THE BRAIN. THIS MAKES IT A KEY PATHWAY OF **INTEROCEPTION** (INTERNAL BODY AWARENESS) FROM YOUR **HEART AND GUT** TO YOUR BRAIN. YOGA CAN IMPROVE YOUR INTEROCEPTION AND **VAGAL FUNCTION**.



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